
Holiday Stress Body Scan

A 5-minute reset for the kind of tension that
doesn't come from physical work

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN SESSIONS BONUS PROTOCOL FOR
the season when invisible tension does visible
damage.

The holidays are hard on your body in a way that's different from physical work. The tension is real but the source is invisible, and most people don't realize how much they're bracing until January.

I see it every year. Clients come in early January — sometimes for “the first time in months” — and their bodies are knotted up worse than they were in October. They didn't shovel, they didn't haul, they didn't do anything physically different. What they did was carry social and emotional stress through six weeks of family gatherings, financial pressure, schedule chaos, and the low-grade vigilance of holiday season.

The body keeps a running tab even when nothing physical is happening to it. The jaw clenches against difficult conversations. The shoulders hike up against family tension. The breath shallows against constant “doing.” The stomach knots against the financial squeeze. None of it is dramatic. All of it accumulates.

This protocol is to interrupt the accumulation before it sets in.

CHAPTER 1

What invisible stress looks like in the body

SIX STATIONS WHERE HOLIDAY STRESS LANDS.

You may notice some, all, or different ones. Knowing where you carry it is half the work.

Jaw

Most people clench during stressful conversations without realizing it. Holidays bring back family dynamics, old conversation patterns, conversations you've been avoiding for months. Your jaw responds before your conscious mind catches up.

The signs: sore jaw in the morning after gatherings, headaches that wrap around your temples, that "tired face" feeling on the drive home.

Shoulders

Shoulders creep up toward your ears when you're bracing against expected difficulty. Around in-laws who criticize. In environments where you don't fully relax. During the financial conversations. During the planning conversations.

The signs: shoulders that feel “high” all day, neck stiffness, headaches at the base of the skull.

Chest

The breath shallows when you’re holding something — words you’re not saying, frustration you’re not expressing, anxiety you’re not naming. The chest tightens, the diaphragm freezes, you breathe up high in your chest instead of down in your belly.

The signs: feeling like you can’t get a full breath, tightness across the front of your chest, a “constricted” feeling that doesn’t have a clear source.

Stomach

Stress hits the gut hard, especially the kind of stress that involves social uncertainty or financial pressure. Your digestive system slows when sympathetic nervous system is active. You feel “knotted up.” Food sits wrong.

The signs: stomach tension that comes and goes with social events, digestive issues that flare during the holidays, that “tight stomach” feeling before a family gathering.

Hands

People clench fists or grip things harder than necessary when they’re holding tension. Watch yourself the next time you’re in a stressful conversation — your hands often tell on you before anything else does.

The signs: tight forearms, sore hands at the end of the day, that “fidgety” feeling that comes from holding tension you’re not releasing.

Hips

The psoas — your deep hip flexor — is a stress muscle. It tightens during fight-or-flight responses and stays tight as long as the stress is active. Chronic holiday stress means chronic psoas tension, which shows up as low back tightness, hip stiffness, and reduced range of motion in your walking gait.

The signs: low back tension that doesn’t track to any physical activity, hip stiffness that’s worse in December than November, walking feeling “stiff” without obvious cause.

CHAPTER 2

The 5-minute scan

YOU CAN DO THIS ANYWHERE. BATHROOM. Parked car. Back porch. Bedroom before sleep. Five minutes total. About 50 seconds per station.

For each station, do the same three steps:

- 1. Notice.** Bring attention to that area of your body. What do you find there? Tension? Bracing? Restriction? Just observe.
- 2. Breathe into it.** Direct your inhale toward that area, as if filling it with breath. Hold for 2 seconds. Long slow exhale.
- 3. Consciously release.** On the exhale, let that area soften. Don't force it. Just give it permission.

Station 1 — Jaw (50 seconds)

Notice your jaw. Are your teeth touching? Is your tongue tense? Is the muscle below your cheekbone clenched?

Breathe into your face. Long exhale. On the exhale, let the jaw drop slightly. Tongue softens. Lips together, teeth apart, tongue on the roof of the mouth.

Station 2 — Shoulders (50 seconds)

Notice your shoulders. Are they up around your ears? Hunched forward? Holding a tension you can feel right now?

Breathe into your shoulders. Long exhale. On the exhale, let them physically drop. You'll be surprised how far they fall once you let them.

Station 3 — Chest (50 seconds)

Notice your chest. Tight across the front? Breathing high in the chest instead of deep in the belly?

Breathe into your belly, not your chest. Long exhale. Let the chest soften. The breath should move your belly, not your shoulders.

Station 4 — Stomach (50 seconds)

Notice your stomach. Knotted? Tight across the front? Holding something?

Breathe into your belly all the way down. Long exhale. On the exhale, let the abdomen soften completely.

Station 5 — Hands (50 seconds)

Notice your hands. Clenched? Holding tension in the fingers? Forearms tight?

Open your fingers wide. Hold for 5 seconds. Drop them completely. Let your hands rest loose.

Station 6 — Hips (50 seconds)

Notice your hips and low back. Tight? Pulled forward? Stiff?

Breathe into your low back. Long exhale. Let the hips and low back soften. Let your weight drop into whatever you're sitting on.

CHAPTER 3

When to use it

THREE TIMES DURING HIGH-STRESS HOLIDAY
days, at minimum:

- **Before** the difficult thing (family gathering, hard conversation, financial decision)
- **After** the difficult thing, before you carry it into the rest of the day
- **Before bed** so you don't carry the day's accumulation into sleep

Plus any time you notice yourself bracing without obvious physical cause.

CHAPTER 4

Permission to leave the room

HERE'S THE PART MOST PEOPLE SKIP: IT'S OKAY to excuse yourself for five minutes during the holidays. Bathroom. Bedroom. Back porch. Parked in the car.

You don't have to perform. You don't have to be available every second. Five minutes alone to reset your nervous system makes you better at the next two hours of presence. It's not selfish — it's maintenance.

The people who hold themselves together through the whole season without ever stepping away are usually the ones who collapse on January 2nd. The people who take 5-minute breaks throughout are usually the ones who make it through with their nervous systems intact.

CHAPTER 5

Closing

WHEN YOU FEEL IT BUILDING — AND YOU WILL — excuse yourself for five minutes and do the scan. Bathroom, car, back porch. Five minutes. Your body will thank you and so will the people at the table.

Holiday stress is real, even when nothing physical is happening. The bodies that come into my office in early January are proof. You don't have to be one of those bodies. The scan takes five minutes. The cost of not doing it is six weeks of accumulating tension that takes months to undo.

Be kind to your body in November and December. It's carrying more than you realize.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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